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Exercises for Syntax

Syntax 1: Grammatical Categories and Word Classes

1. ***Identify the meaning or function of the underlined definite/indefinite article in each of the following.***

   Example: It was a week after Christmas

   Answer: a = 'one'

(a) The wind is whistling around the house.

(b) The door flew open.

(c) The gray cat from next door ran into the house.

(d) A cat is trapped in the cellar.

(e) Yesterday I saw a cat. The cat was wearing a collar.

(f) I like a long-haired cat.

(g) A cat makes a good companion.

(h) The "Puss" I know lives across the street.

2. ***Identify the meaning or function of the present tense in each of the following sentences.***

Example: The chemical composition of water is H2O.

Answer: timeless statement

(a) Still waters run deep.

(b) Classes end November 30.

(c) Janet bites her nails.

(d) I think he was wrong.

(e) Anna Karenina commits suicide.

(f) Yesterday, I'm in a store and it's held up.

(g) The earth revolves around the sun.

(h) We hear that you are going to be a grandparent soon.

(i) The early bird catches the worm.

(j) I know the answer.

(k) Napier passes the ball to Jones.

(l) Phyllis teaches elementary school.

internal use only

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3. *Discuss what each of the following sentences shows concerning the formal expression of the passive.*

Example: The balloons were released.

Answer: agentless be-passive

(a) The kite got tangled in the tree.

(b) The dried mud will brush off.

(c) Your shoes need polishing.

(d) You should brace yourself for the worst.

(e) That is being taken care of.

(f) The dog became confused by the loud noises.

4. *Discuss what each of the following sentences shows concerning the formal expression of the subjunctive.*

Example: Heaven preserve us.

Answer: inflected subjunctive in main clause

(a) I suggest that she take another course.

(b) If I were going, I could take you.

(c) I was thinking of asking you to help.

(d) This might do the trick.

(e) The news is probably bad.

(f) You're right, I'm sure.

Internal use only

5. *Identify the grammatical distinction exemplified by the underlined word or phrase and explain its meaning.*

Example: person: <u>You</u> never can tell.
Answer: 2nd person used for generic purposes

(a) case:	The <u>building's</u> collapse was impressive.
(b) tense:	The moon <u>circles</u> the earth.
(c) aspect:	We <u>have argued</u> since we were children.
(d) tense:	My parents <u>are going to visit</u> next weekend.
(e) definiteness:	I wonder where <u>the</u> remote control is.
(f) number:	<u>Rattlesnakes</u> live in the desert.
(g) gender:	Who is <u>it</u> at the door?
(h) voice:	The dog's tail <u>got caught</u> in the door.
(i) tense:	All's well that <u>ends</u> well.
(j) case:	You should have given <u>Jack</u> the opportunity to answer.
(k) person:	She let <u>me</u> copy her class notes.

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6. Identify the word class of up in each of the following.

(a) Your time is up.

(b) She's in an up mood.

(c) He upped the ante.

(d) The balloons rose up into the sky.

(e) The dog tore up the slipper.

(f) Life is full of ups and downs.

(g) They live just up the street from us.

7. Identify the word class of down in each of the following.

(a) Alex is feeling rather down today.

(b) Would you write your address down for me?

(c) On a dare, he downed the whole beer.

(d) That was a first down, wasn't it?

(e) The computers are down today.

(f) He ran down the stairs.

(g) He looked down because he was embarrassed.

internal use only